

Chapter 08

Feminism

Introduction

Feminism has given birth to feminist criticisms, which have become invaluable to the way in which literature is interpreted though it has acquired a rather negative reputation over the years bringing up feelings of anger, dissatisfaction and images of irrational women. This chapter deals with the aspects of Anglo-American feminist criticism, a branch of second-wave feminism.

However, when looking at the second-wave movement, one needs to first look at the first-wave movement in order to gain greater understanding of Anglo-American feminist criticism. First wave movements began with the 'Women's Rights and Women Suffrage' movements which were the important factors in shaping this phase with their emphasis on social, political and economic reforms (Selden 124). Feminist criticism of the earlier period is more of a reflex of first-wave preoccupations than a fully fledged theoretical discourse of its own.

One of the most influential feminist critics and writers of the first-wave movement is Virginia Woolf. She is the author of many well known literary works and offered the most important literary model to feminists interested in recovering the experience of women writers, especially those in the second-wave movement. Her contributions have greatly influenced the ideas and progressions of second-wave feminism. "Woolf's general contribution to feminism then, is her recognition that *gender identity is socially constructed and can be challenged and transformed*. She also continually examined the problems facing women writers" (Selden 125), which may be clearly seen in her essay, *A Room of One's Own*.

Moving along into the second-wave movement then, Anglo-American feminist criticism is devoted to *the analysis of female fictional characters, the reactions of readers and the lifestyles of the women* but

means of close textual reading and historical scholarship. With regard to the female fictional characters, women's experience became a primary objective in the exposure and further development of a woman's tradition in literature. The more diverse Anglo-American feminism includes such women as Kate Millet, Elaine Showalter, Germaine Greer and Adrienne Rich.

Key Terms Used in Feminism

Ideology: dominant values, beliefs, ways of thinking through which a culture understands reality. Similar to the phrase 'cultural mythology', it usually represents in tacit fashion the prevailing views of a particular class. Examples of ideology relevant to American culture: gender roles, value of capitalism, constitutional rights protecting individual liberties.

Literary Canon: the group of texts deemed to be major works of literary tradition

Gynocriticism: concerns itself with works by women

Hermeneutics of Trust: Interpretive approaches that lend credibility to authorial or rhetorical intentionality, that concern themselves with laying bare the verbal sense in all of its dynamics. Examples: formalism, reader-response

Hermeneutics of Suspicion: involves a resistance to author's intentions or textual design to uncover hidden ideologies or anomalies. Less what the text says; more what the text hides. Examples: Deconstruction, Feminist Literary Criticism, Marxist literary criticism

Other are discussed in the next section, Kate Millet.

Kate Millett

- born 1934 in Minnesota
- author, teacher and artist
- published *Sexual Politics* in 1969

Sex: biological - male and female

Gender: psychological and cultural – masculine and feminine (Millet 29)

Patriarchy: the ideology of male supremacy socialized through temperament, role and status (Millet 26).

Temperament (political): formation of human personality along stereotyped lines of sex category (Millett 26).

For example: Masculine = aggressive/Feminine = passive

Role (sociological): code of conduct, gestures and attitudes for each sex (Millett 26)

For example: women's activity — domestic service and attendance to children.

Status (psychological): prejudice of male superiority guarantees superior male status and inferior female status (Millett 26).

For example: men are granted higher paying jobs; therefore, women are forced to be economically dependent on men.

Female Sexuality: viewed as impure and evil

- menstruation considered a burden
- virginity must be controlled by men because female sexuality is feared

Women denied sexual freedom and biological control through the cult of virginity and the proscription against abortion and birth control (Millett 46-54).

Family: Patriarchy's primary institution of control through male dominance of name and property and socialization of young

- women are excluded from their own name and property
- within marriage, men dominate; therefore, children are socialized to depend on men
- infantilization of women, who must seek approval from men
- women are not remunerated for domestic labour (Millett 33-6)

Elaine Showalter

Showalter's book *A Literature of Their Own* was written to try and shift the focus and concentrate specifically on women's writing, on recuperating a tradition of women authors and on examining in detail women's own culture (Selden 129).

Second wave women celebrate biological attributes as sources of superiority; the experiences exclusive to women is a source of positive values (Selden 128).

Anglo-American feminism centres on 'women' – real, biological entities who are forging a politics based on shared experience and needs (Eagleton 9).

Showalter's Three Phases

- Feminine (1840-80) in which women wrote in an effort to equal the intellectual achievements of the male culture and internalized its assumptions about female nature. The distinguishing sign of this period is the male pseudonym. Women chose male pseudonyms as a way of coping with a double literary standard.
- Feminist (1880-1920) in which women protest male values, advocate separatist 'sisterhoods'. They used literature to dramatize the ordeals of wronged womanhood.
- Female (1920) in which women create 'female writing' in self-discovery. Women reject both imitation and protest – two forms of dependency – and turn instead to female experience as the source of an independent art, extending the feminist analysis of culture to the forms and techniques of literature.

Gynocriticism

It was through *A Literature of Their Own* that she coined the term 'gynocriticism' (Rice 153- 54).

- The programme of gynocritics is to construct a female tradition for the analysis of women's literature, to develop new models based on the study of female experience rather than adopt male models and theories.
- Begins at the point when we free ourselves from the linear absolutes of male literary history, stop trying to fit women between the lines of male tradition and focus instead on the newly visible world of female culture (Rice 149).
- The gynocritic dedicates herself to the female author and character and develops theories and methodologies based on female experience. It also discovers in her authors and characters an understanding of female identity. It does not

expects her authors and her heroines to be superwomen, but the essential struggle will be towards a coherent identity, a realization of selfhood and freedom.

- The most popular sequence in gynocritical reading is from reality, to author, to reader, to reality: there is an objective reality which the author understands and describes truthfully in her text. Moreover, the reader appreciates the validity of the text and relates it to her understanding of her own life.
- In this standard, author, character and reader can unite in an exploration of what it means to be female. They can even assert a collective identity as 'we women'. Whereas, the reader is gratified by having her anger, experience or hopes confirmed by the author and narrative (Eagleton 9).

Germaine Greer

She was a second wave feminist whose book *The Female Eunuch* was 'magnificently accessible' (Wallace 157). Greer wrote this book in 1970 in order to "question the most basic assumptions about 'feminine normality'" (*The Female Eunuch* 14).

The Female Eunuch

In *The Female Eunuch* Greer says she 'argued that every girl child is conceived as a whole woman but from the time of her birth to her death she is progressively disabled' (*The Whole Woman* 4).

- It was a huge success and 'triggered a shock of recognition in tens of thousands of Western women who read it, and in hundreds of thousands of women who received Greer's analysis via the media' (Wallace 160) and it became 'feminism's smash-hit' (Wallace 160).
- Christine Wallace, the author of *Germaine Greer: Untamed Shrew*, criticized *The Female Eunuch* specifically because she felt that book 'is one of the prescriptive extremes of second-wave, every bit as wrong-headed as the other extreme dictating that only lesbians could consider themselves true feminists' (Wallace 164).
- About religion, patriarchy, sexuality, societal roles, marriage and many other topics.

Greer was acclaimed 'the star that feminism was waiting for' (Wallace 174). She was a controversial figure who was criticized a great deal both for her character and her book.

Greer wrote many other books since *The Female Eunuch* including its sequel entitled *The Whole Woman*. Germaine Greer claims she wrote *The Whole Woman* because 'it was time to get angry again' (*The Whole Woman* 3) and because 'the contradictions women face have never been more bruising than they are now' (*The Whole Woman* 3). It almost seems that in this book she is calling back the ideals of second wave feminism.

Adrienne Rich

- 'The woman's body is the terrain on which patriarchy is erected'. Rich
- Concerned with the way women have been oppressed, both materially and psychologically.
- Women are powerless in our patriarchal society. (Evans 83)

In her book, *Of Woman Born*, she discussed motherhood and sexuality.

Motherhood

- Rich denies the existence of an innate mothering instinct, inherent in all women. Instead, she argues that we learn the behaviours associated with motherhood: patience, self-sacrifice, etc. These are not naturally rooted in us. (Evans 83)
- Defines two halves of motherhood: Institution and Experience – the experience of motherhood is a woman's potential relationship to her powers of reproduction and to children; the institution of motherhood is male dominated and ensures that woman's potential remains under male control. (Eisenstein 70)
- The institution of motherhood is oppressing and patriarchal. For example, it is a common belief, especially among men, that due to a woman's ability to have children, all women should have children. (Evans 85)
- Motherhood gives women power – men dislike this and retaliate in the form of oppression.

Lesbian Continuum

- All women are lesbian insofar as they want to identify with other women (Tong 126).
- Redefines lesbianism to mean a range of woman identified experience – such a redefinition makes it a part of 'normal' female experience (Eisenstein 55).
- Does not necessarily refer to physical genital sexual experience. Rather, it is the desire to relate to other women (Eisenstein 56).

Compulsory Heterosexuality

- Argues that heterosexual preference is imposed upon women – it maintains female subordination because it forces women to identify with men (Evans 86).
- Heterosexuality is itself an institution, imposed on women out of man's fear that he might lose woman and with that, will lose the maternal power she bears.

Basics of the Theory

Historically, thinking about gender happens in cultures where gender formations, the social meaning systems that encode sexual difference, go through changes or shifts. The same is true with thinking about race (that race as a construct becomes apparent when ideas of race are shifting) or economics or politics, etc. All of these concepts are re-evaluated when social practice (i.e. what people do) shifts. So gender or masculine and feminine qualities, or male/female social roles, comes up as area for analysis whenever gender roles are shifting. You can trace this back to medieval times; for example, Chaucer's Wife of Bath is certainly an example of questioning gender configurations. Here it should be noted too that questions of gender roles are not limited solely to women thinkers and writers. Since gender roles seem to shift in just about every time period, in relation to all kinds of factors such as war, for instance or economics or notions of morality, gender is often a major focus of thought and writing, in popular culture and in theory.

Certainly in the nineteenth century, in Britain and the United States, gender was a matter for much public discussion and debate. 'The Woman Question', as it was called, focused on whether gender

should be a factor in granting or limiting rights, like voting rights. It also focused attention on men and male social roles, asking questions about the nature and function of gender. Is gender innate and biological? Is it the product of socialization and environment? Is the family structure (one father, one mother and children) eternal, universal, divinely-ordained, natural or socially constructed and thus variable? These were and are central questions not only for politics and economics but also for anthropology, psychology and all of what we now call the social sciences.

Hence why is gender important? The simplest answer is because it is there. 'Gender', meaning the differentiation, usually on the basis of sex, between social roles and functions labelled as 'masculine' and 'feminine', is universal. It is because all societies known to us in all time periods make some sort of gender distinctions. As a central feature of all cultures, gender seems worth attention.

Gender is so ubiquitous as a topic of study in part because of our capacity, in the twenty-first century, to 'deconstruct' gender categories, to defamiliarize what has previously been seen as natural (men are naturally masculine, women are naturally feminine). At some point what Derrida would call a 'rupture' occurred: a moment (or moments) when it became possible to think about gender as a construct, not as a natural or eternal category. Thus our thought systems, philosophies and world views had to think of gender as a variable system, as something created and alterable, not as a given. As Derrida further tells us when our culture is able to think of constructs, to foreground as construction what previously was kept in the background as 'natural', as assumed.

But perhaps the question of why we have to talk about gender so much comes from a different place. Perhaps the real question is, when we talk about gender we are going to end up talking about feminism, not gender. Moreover, we may end up saying women are good, men are bad, and it is going to be an excuse to trash men and talk about how white men are horrible oppressors. However, the real question is, why do we have to talk about all this political stuff, all this stuff about who oppresses whom? It just makes us feel guilty. We do not want to change the world or march in the streets. All we want to do is to read novels and poetry and learn something about how to do that in a better and more sophisticated way. So why we have to talk about feminism anyway.

Let us talk about the word 'feminism' and 'feminist' as in 'feminist theory'. What does it make you think of? Angry bra-burning women, man-hating lesbians, political protesters who just make trouble. Simultaneously, images that bring up anger, dissatisfaction, the desire to change and more specifically, to change us (especially if we are all men). Images of people who are not tolerant, rational, reasonable or willing to accept that since I am a person (male or female) doing the best I can, but I cannot help having been raised in a culture where I learned to be masculine or feminine in ways that these feminists see as harmful, evil and bad.

There is, indeed, some validity to this view. Our definition of feminism would be in *three* parts.

- 1) A 'feminist' is someone who is interested in studying and understanding gender as a system of cultural signs or meanings assigned by various social mechanisms to sexually-dimorphic bodies. One who sees these cultural signs which constitute gender as having a direct effect on how we live our individual lives and how our social institutions operate.
- 2) Secondly, a 'feminist' is someone who sees the gender systems currently in operation (in our culture and in other cultures) as structured by a basic binary opposition – masculine/feminine – in which one term, masculine, is always privileged over the other term, and that this privileging has had the direct effect of enabling men to occupy positions of social power more often than women. (Note: not all men are eligible to occupy these positions of power; other binary oppositions are always also at work, such as old/young, or rich/poor, which will mitigate the effect of gender alone; hence a rich old woman might have more forms of social power than a poor young man. Obviously, too, this formulation depends on the kinds of social power one is discussing. Similarly, some women hold these positions, again dependent on other forms/positions of empowerment (race, class, education, age, physical ability, etc.). But the basic idea is, if you focus only on the male/female distinction, more men will wield social power (historically and cross-culturally) than women.
- 3) A 'feminist' thinks this (points 1 & 2) is wrong and should be changed.

This definition makes feminism into a kind of academic pursuit, where feminists just sit around studying gender relations. As this is an important part of feminism, the idea that one can study gender relations. The gender exists as a signifying system, as sets of cultural signs that can be, and are, manipulated just as any set of signs is.

But there is also a political side to feminism, the side that says let's not just study and analyze these systems but change them. This is where most of our disagreements would come, over whether or not this system should be changed, and if so, how it should be changed. And, more to the point, what my particular individual stake is in having this system change or remain the same. Why do we have to have this *political* dimension? All I want to do is read novels; I do not want to change my mind or my behaviour or the world.

This political dimension depends in part on your definition of politics. Like 'feminism', it is a loaded-coded word. It could mean party politics, elections and caucuses and initiatives and stuff like that. Nevertheless, that is not how 'feminism' is 'political', where the objections to the intersection of politics and academic study come from.

One should remember that reading literary texts or studying philosophy is not really so abstract and ivory-tower an activity. Reading Aristotle and Rousseau does tell us something about 'the real world'. Derrida certainly invites us to think that philosophical systems are worth thinking about – and Derrida, like Lacan and like the Anglo and French feminists think all this abstract stuff is worth studying, not for some intrinsic 'academic' value of its own, but because these philosophical systems determine the conditions, the terms and premises and concepts, on which our daily lives as individuals, and our social institutions, are based. These systems are not so abstract, not so academic, as we once thought – for instance, Rousseau's philosophy (and Plato's, for that matter, and the entire platonic tradition) make possible the concept of individual rights and freedom, and those abstract ideas started revolutions, here and in France and helped construct the democratic society we now live in every day.

So, what we call 'politics' is the understanding of how cultural texts – be they literary, philosophical or physical (in the sense that gender codes are 'texts' written on our bodies and in our psyches) shape our everyday lives. An understanding of how reading texts and writing texts and interpreting texts, can be a means of changing

or reaffirming the ways in which we understand our world and make decisions about our lives. Politics, in this form, is an inherent and inescapable aspect of every branch of academic study – one can choose either to be conscious and articulate about the ‘politics’ of one’s discipline, i.e. how the ideas and concepts and objects of study of one’s discipline do shape the categories through which we understand the real world, or one can choose to remain ignorant of that dimension, or not to concern oneself with that – in which case study will remain ‘academic’, abstract, in the ivory tower.

Politics is about change, but first it is about seeing what Althusser will call our ideological relations, or the ways we represent and therefore comprehend our relations to the material world and to material practices. We shall discuss more about this with some of the up-coming theories in this book, all of which will have a ‘political’ dimension, just as feminist theory does.

Helene Cixous: ‘The Laugh of the Medusa’

Cixous and Irigaray are poststructuralist theoretical feminists. They represent two different but related branches of contemporary feminist theory.

Gilbert’s piece represents what we might call a ‘pragmatic’ American feminist school of thought. Emerging from a tradition called ‘liberal feminism’, this American pragmatic feminism is interested in looking at how systems of female oppression have been perpetuated and elaborated; such analysis usually pays a plenty of attention to history (and hence is not based on structuralist principles of synchronic analysis). Liberal/American feminism often emphasizes understanding origins of social practices, in order to understand how to intervene in them, to change them. That is why we call it ‘pragmatic’: much American feminist thought is oriented towards getting things done, towards theorizing so that some kind of social action or change can take place. This kind of theorizing for application has its roots in a number of political movements and theories, including Marxism and socialism, civil rights, and, of course, the ‘women’s liberation’ movement.

Gilbert’s article represents the historical aspect of this kind of American feminist theory; her article looks specifically at literary history to find that an overwhelming number of male authors have attributed their creative capacity directly to their bodily configuration: the pen, as Gilbert documents, is a metaphoric penis,

and vice-versa. This metaphoric equation between pen and penis is important, Gilbert asserts, because such metaphors shape how we are able to think about the process of writing and about creativity in general. By linking writing with having a penis, these authors insist that writing, being creative, is a biological act, one rooted in the body, and specifically in the male body. Her article shows that this equation is not an isolated incident, something that just a few jerks thought, but rather is one of the dominant metaphors of creativity in Western culture, for both male and female writers.

Now, we can critique this stance pretty easily — how come these guys thought that penises were the physical model or analog for creating, when it is just as 'logical' (and even more self-evident) to say that creativity comes from a female body, since that is, after all, the body that actually gives birth? But that is precisely Gilbert's point: throughout Western cultural history, women have been confined solely to the role of giving birth, of being mothers of human beings. Contrarily, men, meanwhile, have signified their creativity as giving 'birth', as being fathers/progenitors, of immortal things, like books, and not being connected to beings that perish (like people).

There are many ways to read this assertion of male creative fatherhood/authorship/authority. We can see it as an anxious response to the male inability to know for sure that they really are the father of biological children (since only the mother knows for sure who the parents of the child are). We can see it as a reaction-formation (in psychoanalytic terminology) to the threat of castration, by asserting the predominance of the penis (as presence) as creative organ. We can see it as an attempt to reduce what Harold Bloom calls 'the anxiety of influence', the feeling that one will never be as good and powerful as one's father, and particularly as good one's literary forebears, one's literary 'fathers'. Or we can see it as a conscious attempt on the part of male authors deliberately to exclude women writers from membership in their exclusive club, by defining the only 'good' writing as coming from men.

However we decide to interpret the phenomenon Gilbert is describing, it is clear — from her voluminous documentation — that this equation between pen and penis has been a powerful metaphor in Western thought. One which many women authors internalized and which countless women who might have been authors may have internalized and believed and allowed it to prevent them from attempting to wield the pen. Gilbert concludes that the exclusion of

women from the tools of the trade meant that women writers found alternate methods of writing. If they could not use pens/penises, what did they write with? Perhaps they do this with milk, with blood, and on leaves and bark. She means this metaphorically, just as the pen = penis image is a metaphor, but also literally, as the pen = penis image is also meant literally. She means that we must look for women's writing in places and using instruments, not traditionally associated with writing, because those traditions are defined by male authors.

These are themes very similar to those taken up by the poststructuralist theoretical feminists. Gilbert poses the question in her essay, 'If the pen is a metaphorical penis, with what organ can females generate texts?' She finds her answer in images created by women writers. Cixous and Irigaray take up the same question and use the poststructuralist ideas of Derrida and Lacan to come up with some provocative answers.

Helene Cixous takes up where Lacan left off, in noting that women and men enter into the Symbolic Order. They enter into language as structure, in different ways or through different doors, and that the subject positions open to either sex within the Symbolic are also different. She understands that Lacan's naming the centre of the Symbolic as the Phallus highlights what a patriarchal system language is or, more specifically, what a phallo(go)centric system it is.

This idea, that the structure of language is centred by the phallus, produced the word 'phallogocentric'. Derrida's idea that the structure of language relies on spoken words being privileged over written words produced the word 'logocentric' to describe Western culture in general. Cixous and Irigaray combine the two ideas to describe Western cultural systems and structures as 'phallogocentric', based on the primacy of certain terms in an array of binary oppositions. Thus a phallogocentric culture is one which is structured by binary oppositions – male/female, order/chaos, language/silence, presence/absence, speech/writing, light/dark, good/evil, etc. Here the first term is valued over the second term. Cixous and Irigaray insist that all valued terms (male, order, language, presence, speech, etc.) are aligned with each other, and that all of them together provide the basic structures of Western thought.

Cixous follows Lacan's psychoanalytic paradigm, which argues that a child must separate from its mother's body (the Real) in order to enter into the Symbolic. Due to this, Cixous says, the female body

in general becomes unrepresentable in language. It is what cannot be spoken or written in the phallogocentric Symbolic order. Cixous here makes a leap from the maternal body to the female body in general; she also leaps from that female body to female sexuality, saying that female sexuality, female sexual pleasure, is unrepresentable within the phallogocentric Symbolic order.

To understand how she makes that leap, we have to go back to what Freud says about female sexuality, and the mess he makes of it. In Freud's story of the female Oedipus complex, girls have to make abundant switches, from clitoris to vagina, from attraction to female bodies to attraction to male bodies, and from active sexuality to passive sexuality, in order to become 'normal' adults. Cixous rewrites this, via Lacan, by pointing out that 'adulthood', in Lacan's terms, is the same as entering into the Symbolic and taking up a subject position. Thus 'adulthood', or becoming a linguistic subject, for Cixous, means having only one kind of sexuality: passive, vaginal, heterosexual, reproductive. This sexuality, if one follows Freud to his logical extreme, is not about female sexuality per se, but about male sexuality: the woman's pleasure is to come from being passively filled by a penis (remember, Freud defines activity as masculine and passivity as feminine). So, Cixous concludes, there really is not any such thing as female sexuality in and of itself in this phallogocentric system – it is always sexuality defined by the presence of a penis, and not by anything intrinsic to the female body or to female sexual pleasure.

If women have to be forced away from their own bodies such as in the person of the mother's body, and then in the person of their unique sexual feelings/pleasures in order to become subjects in language, Cixous argues, is it possible for a woman to write at all? Is it possible for a woman to write as a woman? Or does entry into the Symbolic, orienting one's language around a centre designated as a Phallus, mean that when one writes or speaks, one always does so as a 'man'? In other words, if the structure of language itself is phallogocentric and stable, meaning is anchored and guaranteed by the Phallus. Further, it is not everyone who uses language taking up a position as 'male' within this structure which excludes female bodies.

Cixous, and other poststructuralist theoretical feminists, are both outraged and intrigued by the possibilities for relations between gender and writing (or language use in general) that Lacan's paradigms open up. That is what Cixous means when she says (p.

309a) that her project has two aims: to break up and destroy, and foresee and project. She wants to destroy (or perhaps just deconstruct) the phallogocentric system Lacan describes and project some new strategies for a new kind of relation between female bodies and language.

Lacan's description of the Symbolic (as illustrated by the pictures on p. 741 of the two doors) places women and men in different positions within the Symbolic in relation to the Phallus. Men more easily misperceive themselves as having the Phallus, as being closer to it, whereas women (because they have no penises) are further from that centre. Because of that distance from the Phallus, the poststructuralist theoretical feminists argue, women are closer to the margins of the Symbolic order. They are not as firmly anchored or fixed in place as men are; they are closer to the Imaginary, to images and fantasies, and further from the idea of absolute fixed and stable meaning than men are.

Since women are less fixed in the Symbolic than men, women and their language are more fluid, more flowing and more unstable than men. It is worth noting here while talking about women and woman, Cixous sometimes means it literally, as the physical being with vaginas and breasts, etc., and sometimes she means it as a linguistic structural position. In this position, 'woman' is a signifier in the chain of signifiers within the Symbolic, just as 'man' is. Both have stable meaning ('woman' is the signifier attached to the signified of vagina and breasts etc.) because both are locked in place, anchored by the Phallus as centre of the Symbolic order. When Cixous says that woman is more slippery, more fluid, less fixed than man, she means both the literal woman, the person, and the signifier 'woman'.

* Cixous' essay is difficult, not only because she is assuming we all know Freud and Lacan's formulations about female sexuality and about the structure of language, but also because she writes on two levels at once. She is always being both metaphoric and literal, referring both to structures and to individuals. When she says that 'woman must write herself', 'woman must write woman', she means both that women must write themselves, tell their own stories (much as the American feminists say women must tell their own stories) and that 'woman' as signifier must have a (new) way to be connected to the signifier 'I', to write the signifier of selfhood/subjecthood offered within the Symbolic order.

Cixous also discusses writing on both a metaphoric and literal level. She aligns writing with masturbation, something that for women is supposed to be secret, shameful or silly, something not quite adult, something that will be renounced in order to achieve adulthood, just like clitoral stimulation has to be renounced in favour of vaginal/reproductive passive adult sexuality. For women to write themselves, Cixous says, they must (re)claim a female-centred sexuality. If men write with their penises, as Gilbert argues, then Cixous says before women can write they have to discover where their pleasure is located. (And don't be too quick to decide that women write with their clitorises. It is not quite that simple).

Cixous also argues that men have not yet discovered the relation between their sexuality and their writing, as long as they are focused on writing with the penis. 'Man must write man', Cixous says. This way, she focuses on 'man' as a signifier within the Symbolic, which is no more privileged than 'woman' as a signifier. In an important footnote, Cixous explains that men's sexuality, like women's, has been defined and circumscribed by binary oppositions (active/passive, masculine/feminine), and that heterosexual relations have been structured by a sense of otherness and fear created by these absolute binaries. As long as male sexuality is defined in these limited and limiting terms, Cixous says, men will be prisoners of a Symbolic order which alienates them from their bodies in ways similar to (though not identical with) how women are alienated from their bodies and their sexualities. Thus, while Cixous does criticize men directly for being patriarchal oppressors, she also identifies the structures which enforce gender distinctions as being oppressive to both sexes.

She also links these oppressive binary structures to other Western cultural practices, particularly those involving racial distinctions. She follows Freud in calling women the 'dark continent' and expands the metaphor by reference to Apartheid to demonstrate that these same binary systems which structure gender also structure imperialism: women are aligned with darkness, with otherness, with Africa, against men who are aligned with lightness, with selfhood and with Western civilization. Cixous also refers to women as 'they', as if women are non-speakers, non-writers, whom she is observing. 'As soon as they begin to speak, at the same time as they are taught their name, they can be taught that their territory is black' i.e. entry into the Symbolic order, into language, into having a self and a name, is entry into these structures of binary oppositions.

Cixous argues that most women do write and speak, but that they do so from a 'masculine' position. In order to speak, women (or 'woman') has assumed she needed a stable, fixed system of meaning and thus has aligned herself with the Phallus which stabilizes language. There has been little or no 'feminine' writing, Cixous says (p. 311). In making this statement, she insists that writing is always 'marked', within a Symbolic order that is structured through binary opposites, including 'masculine/feminine', in which the feminine is always repressed. Remember here, when Cixous speaks of 'feminine' it is both literal and metaphoric - it is something connected to femaleness, to female bodies, and something which is a product of linguistic positioning. So Cixous is arguing that only women could produce feminine writing because it must come from their bodies. Moreover, she argues that men could occupy a structural position from which they could produce feminine writing.

Cixous coins the phrase 'l'écriture féminine' to discuss this notion of feminine writing (and masculine writing, its phallogocentric counterpart). She sees 'l'écriture féminine' first of all as something possible only in poetry (in the existing genres), and not in realist prose. Novels, she says on p. 311, are 'allies of representationalism' - they are genres (particularly realist fiction) which try to speak in stable language, language with one-to-one fixed meanings of words; language where words seemingly point to things and not to the structure of language itself. In poetry, however, language is set loose because the chains of signifiers flow more freely. Meaning is less fixed; poetry, Cixous says, is thus closer to the unconscious, and thus to what has been repressed (and thus to female bodies/female sexuality). This is one model she uses to describe what 'l'écriture féminine' looks like. (It is worth noting, however, that all the poet and 'feminine' writers Cixous mentions specifically are men.)

Such feminine writing will serve as a rupture, or a site of transformation or change. She means 'rupture' here in the Derridean sense, a place where the totality of the system breaks down and one can see a system as a system or structure, rather than simply as *the truth*. Feminine writing will show the structure of the Symbolic as a structure, not as an inevitable order, and thus allow us to deconstruct that order.

There are two levels on which 'l'écriture féminine' will be transformative, Cixous argues (p. 311-312), and these levels correspond again to her use of the literal and the metaphoric, or the

individual and the structural. On one level, the individual woman must write herself, must discover for herself what her body feels like, and how to write about that body in language. Specifically, women must find their own sexuality, one that is rooted solely in their own bodies, and find ways to write about that pleasure, which Cixous, following Lacan, names 'jouissance' (orgasm, pleasure). On the second level, when women speak/write their own bodies, the structure of language itself will change. As women become active subjects, not just beings passively acted upon, their position as subject in language will shift. Women who write – if they do not merely reproduce the phallogocentric system of stable ordered meaning which already exists (and which excludes them) – will be creating a new signifying system. This system may have built into it far more play, more fluidity, than the existing rigid phallogocentric symbolic order. 'Beware, my friend', Cixous writes towards the end of the essay (p. 319) 'of the signifier that would take you back to the authority of a signified!'

The woman who speaks, Cixous says, and who does not reproduce the representational stability of the Symbolic order, will not speak in linear fashion, will not 'make sense' in any currently existing form. *L'écriture féminine*, like feminine speech, will not be objective/objectifiable. It will erase the divisions between speech and text, between order and chaos, between sense and nonsense. In this way, *l'écriture féminine* will be an inherently deconstructive language. Such speech/writing (and remember, this language will erase that slash) will bring users closer to the realm of the Real, back to the mother's body, to the breast, to the sense of union or non-separation. This is why Cixous uses (p.312) the metaphor of 'white ink', of writing in breast milk; she wants to convey that idea of a reunion with the maternal body, an unalienated relation to female bodies in general.

Cixous' descriptions of what '*l'écriture féminine*' looks like (or, better, sounds like, since it is not clear that this writing will 'look like' anything – since 'looking like' is at the heart of the misperception of self in the Mirror Stage which launches people into the Symbolic order) flow into metaphors, which she also means literally. She wants to be careful to talk about writing in new ways, in ways that distinguish *l'écriture féminine* from existing forms of speech/writing, and in so doing she is associating feminine writing with existing non-linguistic modes. So, for instance, *l'écriture féminine* is milk, it's a song, something with rhythm and pulse, but no words. It is also

something connected with 'beats' and movements, but not with representational language.

She uses these metaphors also to be 'slippery', arguing (p. 313) that one cannot define the practice of 'l'écriture féminine'. To define something is to pin it down, to anchor it, to limit it, to put it in its place within a stable system or structure. Cixous says that l'écriture féminine is too fluid for that; it will always exceed or escape any definition. It cannot be theorized, enclosed, coded, or understood. It, however, does not mean it does not exist. Rather, it will always be greater than the existing systems for classification and ordering of knowledge in phallogocentric western culture. It cannot be defined, but it can be 'conceived of' by subjects not subjugated to a central authority. Only those on the margins, the outlaws, can 'conceive of' feminine language. Those outlaws will be women, and anyone else who can resist or be distanced from the structuring central Phallus of the phallogocentric Symbolic order.

In discussing who might exist in the position of outlaw, Cixous brings up (p. 314) the question of bisexuality. Again, she starts from Freud's idea that all humans are fundamentally bisexual, and that the Oedipal trajectory which steers both boys and girls into heterosexuality is an unfortunate requirement of culture. For Cixous, 'culture' is always a phallogocentric order. The entry into the Symbolic requires the division between male and female, feminine and masculine, which subordinates and represses the feminine. But by erasing/deconstructing the slash between masculine and feminine, Cixous is not arguing for Freud's old idea of bisexuality. Rather, she wants a new bisexuality, the 'other bisexuality', which is the 'nonexclusion either of the difference or of one sex' — a refusal of self/other as a structuring dichotomy. In essence, rather than scotch-taping masculine and feminine together, Cixous' bisexuality would dissolve the distinctions, so that sexuality would be from any body, any site, at any time.

Cixous says that without the dichotomy of self/other, all other dichotomies would start to fall apart. Her other bisexuality would thus become a deconstructive force to erase the slashes in all structuring binary oppositions. When this occurs, the Western cultural representations of female sexuality, i.e. the myths associated with womanhood will also fall apart. Cixous focuses in particular (p. 315) on the myth of the Medusa, the woman with snakes for hair, whose look will turn men into stone, and on the myth of woman as

black hole, as abyss. The idea of woman as abyss or hole is pretty easy to understand; in Freudian terms, a woman lacks a penis, and instead has this scary hole in which the penis disappears and might not come back. Freud reads the Medusa as part of the fear of castration, the woman whose hair is writhing penises; she is scary, not because she has got too few penises, but because she has too many. Cixous says those are the fears that scare men into being complicit in upholding the phallogocentric order: they are scared of losing their one penis when they see women as having either no penis or too many penises. If women could show men their true sexual pleasures, their real bodies, i.e. by writing them in non-representational form, Cixous says, men would understand that female bodies, female sexuality, is not about penises (too few or too many) at all. That is why she says we have to show them 'our sexts' – another new word, the combination of sex and texts, the idea of female sexuality as a new form of writing.

Cixous then moves on to talk about the idea of hysterics as prior examples of women who write 'sexts', who write their bodies as texts of *l'écriture féminine*. Again, she is following Freud, whose earliest works were on hysteria and focused on female hysterics. The idea of hysteria is that a body produces a symptom, such as the paralysis of a limb, which represents a repressed idea; the body thus 'speaks' what the conscious mind cannot say, and the unconscious thoughts are written out by the body itself. *L'écriture féminine* has a lot in common with hysterics, as you can see, in the idea of the direct connections between the unconscious and the body as a mode of 'writing'.

Cixous concludes the essay (starting on p. 318) by offering a critique of the Freudian nuclear family, the mom-dad-child formation, which she sees as generating the ideas of castration (Penisneid, in German) and lack which form the basis for ideas of the feminine in both Freudian and Lacanian psychoanalysis. She wants to break up these 'old circuits' so that the family formations which uphold the phallogocentric Symbolic will not be recreated every time a child is born. She argues that this family system is just as limiting and oppressive to men as to women, and that it needs to be 'demater-paternalized'.

Then she discusses other ways to figure pregnancy, arguing that, like all functions of the female body, pregnancy needs to be written, in '*l'écriture féminine*'. When pregnancy is written, and the female body figured in language as the source of life, rather than the

penis, birth can be figured as something other than as separation or lack.

She ends with the idea of formulating desire as a desire for everything. It is not for something lacking or absent, as in the Lacanian Symbolic. It is a new desire which would strip the penis of its significance as the signifier of lack or of fulfilment of lack, and would free people to see each other as different beings, each of whom are whole, and who are not complementary. These beings, not defined by difference, absence, or even by gender, would begin to form a new kind of love, a love which she describes on 319-320, in the paragraph beginning *Other love . . .*

Principles of Feminism

If you want to read a text from a generalist feminist perspective, you need to:

1. Scan the text for:
 - Traditional female stereotyping. See if the woman in the text you read is described as an angel, mad temptress and witch, false and cheat, etc.
 - General accusations about women. Try to find if the text accuses women of sentimentality, irrationality, conspiracy, passivity, etc.
 - Abuses and derision. See if the text belittles women's achievement, pokes fun on them and hurls abuses.
 - Deliberate omission of women altogether from narrative where they should be.
2. Once you fall upon the requested stereotypes, generalizations or omissions inserted implicitly or explicitly in the narrative, you have next to read the text against the grain of a masculine dominated culture that determines both reading and writing. This is to say, if you are a male reader, you should read against yourself and against your impulses. If you are a female reader, you should be able to see the male biases in the narrative so that you can expose their falsity.
3. Look for the language used in the text. Observe whether the text uses traditional and conventional language patterns associated with the male order, or whether

language is used unconventionally, and thus associated with the female order. Marks of unconventionality include loss or multiplicity of voices in a narrative, parody, fluidity of expression, bricolage, repetition, exaggeration, whimsy, multiple viewpoint and jouissances.

4. While reading bear in mind the two Lacanian orders: the symbolic and the imaginary. The symbolic implies the detachment of the narrative and the narrator from the mother's body under the fear of symbolic castration by the patriarch. The imaginary order suggests a narrative or a narrator completely fused with the body of the mother, with no showing of any signs of fear from the patriarch.
5. Examine representation of women in literature by men and women, and challenge representation of women as 'Other', as 'lack', and as part of 'nature'. Moreover, raise the question of whether men and women are essentially different because of biology, or are socially constructed as different.

Advantages

Women have been somewhat underrepresented in the traditional cannon, and a feminist approach to literature redresses this problem.

Disadvantages

Feminist turn literary criticism into a political battlefield and overlook the merits of works they consider 'patriarchal'. When arguing for a distinct feminine writing style, they tend to relegate women's literature to a ghetto status. This in turn prevents female literature from being naturally included in the literary cannon. The feminist approach is often too theoretical.

Example

Showalter's three stages of feminine, feminist, and female are identifiable in the life of Cleófilas in Sandra Cisneros's 'Woman Hollering Creek'.

Cleófilas begins to internalize the paternalistic values of the society in which she lives at least as early as the ice house scene. She 'accompanies her husband'; as is expected of her (48). Since women should be seen and not heard in a paternalistic society, she 'sits mute

beside their conversation' (48). She goes through all of the motions that are expected of her, laughing 'at the appropriate moments' (48). She submits, if unhappily, to the rule of her husband, 'this man, this father, this rival, this keeper, this lord, this master, this husband till kingdom come' (49).

Yet Cleófilas gradually begins to emerge from the feminine stage into the feminist stage, where she begins to revolt and advocate for her own rights. It begins with '[a] doubt. Slender as a hair' (50). When she returns from the hospital with her new son, something seems different. 'No. Her imagination. The house was the same as always. Nothing' (50). This is true because the house is not different; it is Cleófilas who has begun to change. Perhaps giving birth to a child has made her aware of the power and importance women possess. She begins to think of returning home, but is not ready for the possibility yet. It would be 'a disgrace' (50). She begins to internally protest against the society, thinking about the town 'with its silly pride for a bronze pecan' and the fact that there is 'nothing, nothing, nothing of interest' (50). The patriarchal society, with its ice house, city hall, liquor stores, and bail bonds is of no interest to her. She is upset that the town is built so that 'you have to depend on husbands' (51). Though her husband says she is 'exaggerating', she seems to be becoming convinced that her society is a bad one, where men kill their wives with impunity. 'It seemed the newspapers were full of such stories. This woman found on the side of the interstate. This one pushed from a moving car . . .' (52). Although she does nothing when he throws a book at her, Cleófilas does (if only meekly) insist that he take her to the doctor. And there she solidifies her internal rebellion with actions: she leaves her husband with Felice to return to Mexico.

Felice is actually more representative of the third, female, stage than Cleófilas, but the fact that Cleófilas enjoys her company suggests that when she returns to Mexico, she may seek to enter that third stage herself. Felice is not phalocentric — she is not interested in revolting against men, she simply does not need them. She does not have a husband and she owns her own car. 'The pickup was hers. She herself had chosen it. She herself was paying for it' (55). Felice is most likely a part of a community of women; she is certainly friends with the nurse Graciela. Cleófilas is attracted to Felice, who 'was like no woman she'd ever met' (55). At home, in Mexico, Cleófilas recounts the story of Felice's yelling when they crossed the creek. 'Just like

that. Who would've thought?' (56). Cleófilas seems to have enjoyed her company and has kept the experience in her mind. Felice's laughter, 'gurgling out of her own throat, a long ribbon of laughter, like water' suggests that Felice had completed the self-discovery stage. (Water is often symbolic of rebirth.) Cleófilas has witnessed the third stage in Felice, and it is up to her whether she will enter it or regress to the feminine stage and internalize the paternalistic values of her father and brothers with whom she is now living.

Critique

Some people think that the feminist movement was built on exaggerations of a patriarchal society; that if any gender inequality existed at all, it has since been rectified. In fact, some people even argue that the feminist movement has already achieved its goals. They say that men and women are now on almost equal footing. They can be lawyers, CEOs, police officers or enter into any other male dominated profession.

Some anti-feminists feel that not only have women achieved equal footing with men, but that women are now attempting to seek a higher status over men, also known as misandry. They point out many aspects of daily life naturally favouring women in today's world. For instance, women have the right to abortion. Stemming from this one right, the anti-feminist movement uses the following arguments. If a woman chooses to keep the baby, the male is then required to support said child until its eighteenth birthday. Custody of a child is almost exclusively granted to its mother unless the child's father can prove she is unfit, which is generally hard to do since the mother is the primary caregiver in most cases. There are also arguments against affirmative action, which was originally meant to protect against discrimination in the work place and in education. However, some argue that affirmative action has made it so that the job market favours women slightly as companies are afraid to hire a man over a woman for fear of being sued.

There are also other gender biases they claim favour women in the workplace as well. They point out that women are more often hired as teachers, daycare operators, and nurses, yet there are no cries of gender discrimination in these fields.

People who insist that feminism has achieved what it set out to do point to all of these arguments as proof that women are now on a level playing field with men.

Conclusion

This approach analyzes the representation of women in literature. Though the projects of individual critics differ, there is general agreement that interpretation of literature involves critique of patriarchy. Patriarchy = ideology that privileges masculine ways of thinking/points of view and marginalizes women politically, economically and psychologically.

For some (French influence), project of interpretation is to expose patriarchal nature of language itself. This involves usage that denigrates or ignores women. It also includes the deeper view that a masculine style of language has suppressed a feminine one. Women need to assert a feminine language. What would this be like? Some have argued that it would be more fluid, less straightforward and logical, more perceptual, open to ongoing semiosis.

Some authors (American) explore texts in detail, demonstrating patriarchal patterns, or the complex response of women writers to their own authorial status.

Some explore challenges to a literary canon that is so dominated by men. This means the insertion of ignored female writers (e.g. Kate Chopin, Charlotte Perkins Gilman) into the canon. It also entails the study of a literary tradition of women writers.

In the sense that this criticism often explores less what the text overtly says but what it hides (e.g. unquestioning attitude towards ideologically entrenched ideas about women).

Feminist literary criticism has given us an opportunity to look at 'women' in literature from women's point of view. It is concerned with women as the producer of textual meanings with the history, themes, genres and structures of literature by women.

Some Important Concepts

"I'm not a feminist — 'I like men!'"

"I'm not a feminist — I think women should be able to stay at home and raise children if they want to!"

"I'm not a feminist — I wear a bra!"

Contrary to the opinions of many students new to the study of feminist literary criticism, many feminists like men, think that women should be able to stay at home and raise children if they want to do

so, and wear bras. Broadly defined, feminist criticism examines the ways in which literature (and other cultural productions) reinforce or undermine the economic, political, social and psychological oppression of women. However, just as the practitioners of all critical theories do, feminist critics hold many different opinions on all of the issues their discipline examines. In fact, some feminists call their field feminisms in order to highlight the multiplicity of points of view of its supporters and offer ways of thinking that oppose the traditional tendency to believe there is a single best point of view. Yet many of us who are new to the study of feminist theory, both male and female, have decided ahead of time that we are not feminists, because we don't share whatever feminist point of view we have found the most objectionable. In other words, before we even come to the theory classroom, many of us have reduced feminism to whatever we consider its most objectionable element and, on that basis, have rejected it. This attitude reveals, I think, the oversimplified, negative view of feminism that still persists in our culture today.

Traditional gender roles cast men as rational, strong, protective, and decisive; they cast women as emotional (irrational), weak, nurturing, and submissive. These gender roles have been used very successfully to justify such inequities, which still occur today, as excluding women from equal access to leadership and decision-making positions (in the family as well as in politics, academia and the corporate world), paying men higher wages than women for doing the same job (if women are even able to obtain the job), and convincing women that they are not fit for careers in such areas as mathematics and engineering. Many people today believe such inequities are a thing of the past because anti-discriminatory laws have been passed, such as the law that guarantees women equal pay for equal work.

Some Questions Feminist Critics Ask about Literary Texts

The questions that follow are offered to summarize feminist approaches to literature. Approaches that attempt to develop a specifically female framework for the analysis of women's writing (such as #4 and #5 below) are often referred to as gynocriticism.

1. What does the work reveal about the operations (economically, politically, socially or psychologically) of patriarchy? How are women portrayed? How do these portrayals relate to the gender issues of the period in which the novel was written or is set?

2. What does the work imply about the possibilities of sisterhood as a mode of resisting patriarchy and about the ways in which women's situations in the world – economic, political, social or psychological – might be improved?
3. What does the work suggest about the ways in which race, class and other cultural factors intersect with gender in producing women's experience?
4. What does the work suggest about women's creativity? In order to answer this question, biographical data about the author and historical data about the culture in which she lived will be required.
5. What might an examination of the author's style contribute to the ongoing efforts to delineate a specifically feminine form of writing (*écriture féminine*)?
6. What does the history of the work's reception by the public and by the critics tell us about the operations of patriarchy? Has the literary work been ignored or neglected in the past? Why? Or, if recognized in the past, is the work ignored or neglected now? Why?
7. What role does the work play in terms of women's literary history and literary tradition?

Furthermore, the key points of Feminist Analysis are:

1. Language, institutions and social power structures have reflected patriarchal interests throughout much of history; and this has had a profound impact on women's ability to express themselves and the quality of their daily lives.
2. Yet at the same time, women have resisted and subverted patriarchal oppression in a variety of ways.
3. This combination of patriarchal oppression and women's resistance to it is apparent in many literary and other cultural texts.
4. For some feminists, the most important way to resist patriarchy is to challenge laws and other institutional barriers to women's equality.

5. For more essentialist feminists, resistance often means focusing on differences between men and women as well as ensuring the social valuation and expression of the latter's unique abilities.
6. For feminists interested in issues of race and ethnicity, both sexism and racism demand analysis in literary and other cultural texts.
7. For materialist feminists, resistance to patriarchy must include thorough questioning of the class system as well as the gender system.
8. For post-structuralist feminists, man/woman is a hierarchical binary that may be challenged through intense critical scrutiny.

